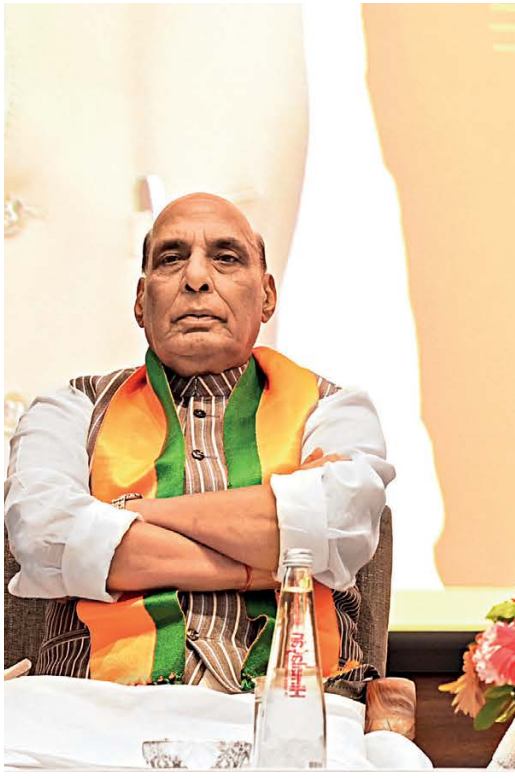




BJP-watchers say that while Ambekar said nothing new, it was the timing that set off alarms. The saffron party is going through a churn, with the unexpected reverses in the general election placing it on the back foot, unsure and indecisive after a very long time. What changes a few months have brought: in April, they were still talking about a commanding victory for the BJP, 370-plus seats was a sure thing, "*chaar sau paar*" was still on the table. Nadda was talking about the party being "self-sufficient", no longer an underling of the RSS, and allies in the states were climbing down from their perches, desperate to be accommodated at the high table.

The rude reality check came on June 4, when it became clear that Modi 3.0 was not going to be a BJP government but a National Democratic Alliance (NDA) one. It robbed the party of the sure-footedness of its first two terms. The underwhelming poll results spurred the RSS to shed its reticence and start articulating its misgivings. Sarsanghchalak Mohan Bhagwat, the organisation's chief, has been unsparing on more than one occasion in the past two months, talking about how man can "aspire for *vishwaroop*" but "nobody is certain of what lies ahead", and "how true *sevak*s should never be arrogant". No one was in the dark about who he was referring to.

At the Centre, the pressures of coalition politics, too, are beginning to tell as contentious policy decisions, such as introducing lateral entry into the civil service, once rammed through in the House, were withdrawn or kept in abeyance. Elsewhere, many of the party's state units, especially in the heartland states, are in turmoil. Add to this the ever-growing confidence of the Opposition and the tough battle ahead in the three states—Maharashtra, Haryana and Jharkhand—and one Union Territory—Jammu & Kash-

RSS VS BJP: TH

THE DIFFERENCES

- **The timing of the RSS's conditional nod for a national caste census—at its Aug. 31–Sept. 2 *baithak*—has put the BJP in a spot. It has so far advocated against the idea**
- **RSS leaders are of the opinion that the UCC, amendments to Waqf Board Properties Act along with other pro-Hindutva moves should be pushed, but in consultation with moderate Muslim/minority groups**
- **RSS remains uncomfortable with turncoats (those with an anti-Sangh ideology) being inducted into the BJP and given prominent positions, irking loyalists**
- **The Sangh is against the overcentralisation of decision-making in the BJP, which it believes leaves it in the hands of a chosen few. So, apart from the RSS, it seeks the involvement of other national and state leaders**